

Child Care Action Plan 2024 Update

RECOMMENDATION:

None.

PREVIOUS COUNCIL/COMMITTEE ACTION

December 6, 2022 – *Committee of Council received the first Child Care Action Plan update.*

December 8, 2020 – *Committee of Council received the Child Care Action Plan.*

REPORT SUMMARY

This report provides Council with an update on the number of new licensed child care spaces in relation to the targets set out in the Child Care Action Plan (the “Action Plan”) and also highlights new provincial initiatives from the Province’s ChildCareBC Plan that may contribute to the creation of new child care spaces in Port Coquitlam.

BACKGROUND

The Port Coquitlam Child Care Action Plan identifies gaps, sets targets for new licensed child care spaces, and recommends 30 actions to reach these targets. In 2021, Council updated City bylaws and policies to support the creation of new licensed child care spaces within the community and requested that staff provide regular progress updates in relation to implementation of the child care related actions and achieving targets for new licensed child care spaces. The first update report was provided in late 2022 and confirmed the success of the bylaw and policy changes in supporting the creation of additional spaces and interest from child care operators.

DISCUSSION:

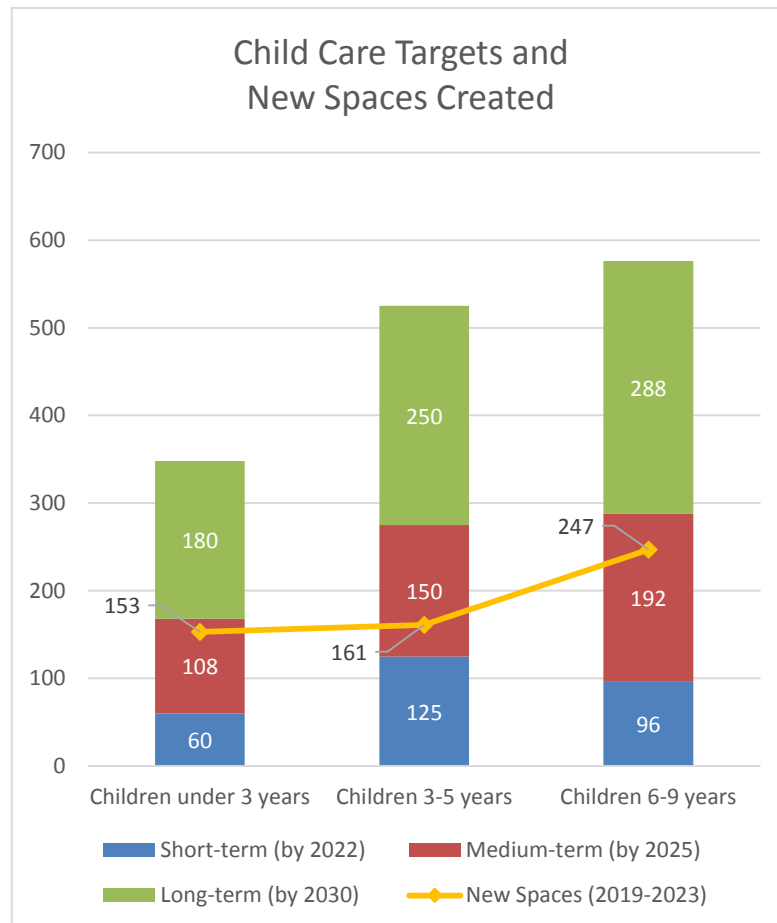
New licensed spaces: The Action Plan recommends targets for the creation of new licensed child care spaces in three age groups, as shown in the table below, to improve accessibility. These targets focus on group programs and exclude part-time preschool spaces or multi-age daycares within the operators’ homes.

Table 1: Recommended Targets for New Child Care Spaces

	2019	2030 Target	New Spaces Needed
Children under 3 years	15 spaces/100 children	33 spaces/100 children	348 spaces
Children 3-5 years	44 spaces/100 children	75 spaces/100 children	525 spaces
Children 6-9 years	23 spaces/100 children	42 spaces/100 children	576 spaces

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The targets are further broken down into short-term (by 2022), medium-term (by 2025) and long-term (by 2030) as shown in the bar graph below. The Action Plan recommends the City target adding 281 new spaces by 2022, 450 new additional spaces by 2025 and 718 new additional spaces by 2030 for a total of 1449 new spaces (approximately 145 new spaces each year).



Recommended Targets for New Spaces in Short, Medium and Long-Term

When the Action Plan was complete (2019), Port Coquitlam had a total of 2,245 licensed child care spaces (including spaces in preschools and multi-age programs in operators' homes). While some facilities have closed, the overall number of licensed spaces has increased by 583 spaces to 2,828 by the end of 2023 which works out to approximately 145 new spaces per year.

New spaces over the last couple of years are primarily attributed to the opening of the Alex Early Care & Learning Centre on Prairie Ave, ABC Kids World Learning Center on Westwood St, Learning Lab Kids Club at the Our Lady of Assumption School and additional before and after school spaces at Irvine Elementary School. Grants from the provincial New Spaces Fund contributed to the creation of new spaces at the Alex Early Care & Learning Centre and Irvine Elementary School.

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Table 2: Child Care Spaces by Program

Group Program by Age	2019 Spaces	2021 Spaces	2023 Spaces	Difference (2021-2023)
Infant/Toddler (under 3 years)	272	366	425	+ 59
Preschooler Age (3-5 years)	655	776	816	+ 40
School Age (6-9 years)	689	769	936	+ 167
Other programs (Multi-age, etc.)	629	627	651	+ 24
TOTAL	2,245	2,538	2828	+ 290

In addition, a number of potential child care facilities are either under construction or under review, which could create approximately 350 new child care spaces in the next several years. Additional child care facilities/spaces are anticipated which could increase the number to 600, but proposals are still in the enquiry stage.

Provincial Programs and Regulations: The Province of BC continues to provide a number of initiatives to improve the affordability, accessibility and quality of child care across the province through their 10-year ChildCareBC Plan. Many of the initial programs, such as New Spaces Fund and \$10 per day ChildCareBC centres, are still available and have been expanded. No additional child care facilities in Port Coquitlam have been awarded under these programs since staff's update in December 2022.

New provincial initiatives which may positively impact Port Coquitlam families and daycare operators worth noting are:

- Seamless Day Kindergarten in which child care is provided before and after school in the same classroom the kindergarten students occupy during school hours. At the moment SD43 does not have any classrooms out of the 45 classrooms across the province participating in the pilot program.
- New ChildCareBC Operating Funding Model (OFM) will be tested with 50 of the \$10 per day ChildCareBC centres to enhance the way operational funding is delivered to providers. The OFM will test the transition from the current market-based system to a publicly funded child care delivery model.
- New intake for the New Spaces Fund will open in April 2024 with new guidelines and application requirements. More information is expected in the next month.

New Legislation Changes: Through the 2023 Housing Statutes Amendments (Bill 44, Bill 46, Bill 47) enacted by the Province, local governments have been given direction to update their Zoning Bylaws and Official Community Plans to reflect expected growth in their communities up to 20 years. In addition, Bill 46 introduced framework for Amenity Cost Charges (ACC), a new tool local governments may utilize to fund future community amenities such as community centres, libraries and child care facilities. Staff are reviewing the possibility of utilizing ACCs and how this tool can

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further increase the creation of child care spaces within Port Coquitlam to meet targets in the Action Plan.

Reassessment of the current targets and recommended actions in the Action Plan may be warranted in the future once staff has a better understanding of how the new legislation impacts the development of new child care spaces.

CONCLUSION

Staff continue to see great interest from child care operators in creating more child care spaces in both residential and commercial facilities in Port Coquitlam. The number of licensed spaces has increased overall and are expected to further increase with new projects under review. Reaching the recommended targets in the Action Plan may be possible through new development applications, updated City policies and continued financial support from the provincial and federal governments.

FINANCIAL IMPLICATIONS

None associated with this report.

ATTACHMENTS

None.

Lead author(s): Natalie Coburn